so many great days, he deserved so much better than to finish on such a dismal day at The Oval.

Russell Domingo had been a member of Gary's team for two years, and he was rightly promoted to take over as head coach. I knew him to be an exceptional person, and I knew I would enjoy working with him.

But sportsmen are nothing if not resilient and, as ever, after suffering a major disappointment, we moved on to the next challenge, and the next tour. There would be no soft landing for us, and no easy start for Russell, as we headed to play five one-day internationals and three T20 matches in Sri Lanka.

Kumar Sangakkara welcomed us to his world with an astonishing innings of 169 off 137 balls in the first match, and then, as ever smart, humble and level-headed, he welcomed us to dinner at his restaurant in Colombo. I did lose five out of five tosses in the series, but Angelo Mathews managed his team with tremendous skill and the home side deserved their 4–1 win. We did salvage some pride, however, winning the T20 series 2–1.

We set out on the road again in October, playing two Tests against Pakistan in the UAE; the first Test was lost in Abu Dhabi, our first defeat in 15 Tests, but we bounced back to win the second Test in Dubai, a match at which Graeme wrote yet another chapter in his book of great innings for South Africa.

He had been under pressure. Some were doubting his form. Others questioned. He made them all look fools by scoring 234 runs in more than 10 hours at the crease, concentrating, straining every sinew for the cause. I was privileged to bat alongside him in a partnership that added 338 runs for the fifth wicket. My innings of 164 paled by comparison, and we won the Test by an innings and 92 runs.

There is a photograph of me hugging Graeme when he had reached his century, with him lifting me clean off the ground. I posted it on Twitter